PROJECT DOCUMENT

Mitsue Project

御杖村プロジェクト概要 / Mitsue Village Project — Summary

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One-Page Briefing for Mitsue Village Government

What We Propose

To repurpose the **Mitsue Taiken Koryukan** (御杖体験交流館) — an available community exchange center and the leading candidate site (final choice confirmed in Phase 1) — as a **community sustainability center** that will:

1. Restore aging cedar (sugi) plantations to healthy native forest — native broadleaf trees feed local wildlife, reducing crop raids by deer, wild boar, and bear; thinning the sugi also generates biomass fuel for the village energy system
2. Generate the village's electricity and heat from sugi forest thinnings through a biomass CHP system — a circular energy economy where the forest powers the village, complemented by solar, EV charging, and community backup power (battery storage subject to feasibility study)
3. House a small, low-impact data center powered by that local energy — a working model of progress and sustainability as a single coherent system

A 25-year initiative built carefully, in close partnership with the village.

This Project Delivers Your Own Renewable Energy Plan

The Mitsue Project is the **implementation and operating vehicle (官民連携 運営体制)** for the village's official **"Plan for Maximum Introduction of Renewable Energy"** (御杖村再エネ導入最大化計画, Jan 2025) — the MoE-funded strategy the village has already written and committed to. We do not ask the village to adopt a new idea; we offer to execute the plan it already has.

- **The "one resilient site" target.** Your plan sets a target of **one** renewable + storage + EV resilient site in the village by 2045 — currently **zero**. Our data center, with on-site biomass CHP generation and battery backup, can credibly **be** that site, letting the village report progress against its own published indicator.
- **EV charging priority.** Your plan makes EV chargers at public facilities (town hall, roadside stations) a **priority**, because transport is **46% of village emissions** — the largest source. Our EV charging network anchored to local generation delivers exactly this.
- **Distributed disaster-resilience.** Your plan calls for an autonomous, distributed energy society that can power public buildings and clinics during outages. Our 24/7 biomass CHP + solar + battery provides this.
- **Forest carbon / J-Credit mechanism — uniquely ours.** Your plan wants forest CO_2 absorption (0.3 → **2.7 kt/yr** by 2045) and a J-Credit system, but has no operator or offtaker for the thinnings. Our biomass CHP **is** that mechanism: it consumes sugi thinnings, funding faster thinning and native restoration, producing the certified forest carbon the plan calls for.
- **Funding that flows through the village.** Because the village completed the MoE planning grant (step 1), it is eligible for the **地域脱炭素移行・再エネ推進交付金** (step 2): a **2/3–3/4 subsidy** on solar/battery/EV/private-wire capex (Mitsue qualifies as a 過疎 + low-financial-capacity area). The grant is paid **to the village** via public-private partnership — the village brings the plan and the grant channel; we bring the operator, capital, and anchor offtaker.

The village's published figures: 9 kt-CO_2 emissions, 46% transport, ~90% forest cover, 60% reduction by 2030, carbon-neutral by 2045. Source: 御杖村再エネ導入最大化計画（概要版）, Jan 2025.

Direct Benefits to Mitsue Village

- **Local employment** — forestry work, facility operations, maintenance roles
- **Income for landowners** — fair compensation to private mountain owners for sugi harvesting
- **Lower energy costs** — locally generated biomass and solar power for the village
- **Circular forest-to-energy economy** — sugi thinnings fuel the village's biomass CHP system, turning a forest liability into local energy
- **EV charging infrastructure** — Mitsue prepared for the coming shift to electric vehicles, powered by the local energy system
- **New use for the Taiken Koryukan** — preserving and honoring an important community facility
- **Reduced cedar pollen** — gradual replacement of sugi with native species over decades
- **Reduced wildlife crop damage** — restored native forest provides natural food for deer, wild boar, and bear, keeping them out of agricultural areas
- **Broadband and digital infrastructure** — improved connectivity for residents and businesses
- **National and international visibility** — Mitsue as a model village for sustainable rural revitalization

Early Benefits — Visible Within Five Years

The 25-year horizon applies to forest restoration ecology. Concrete benefits to the village arrive much earlier:

Year	Tangible benefit to the village
1	Taiken Koryukan reactivated as datacenter hub; village named in domestic and international press; first researcher and student visits
2	First forestry contracts → direct cash income to private mountain owners
2–3	Reduced sugi pollen and landslide risk in actively managed plots
3–4	EV charging stations operational; battery storage if confirmed by feasibility study
4–5	Data center hires local staff; hosting fees and energy sales become real revenue; village becomes a study-tour destination
Ongoing	Community programmes, field trips, and open environmental and financial dashboards from Year 1 onward

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Economic Value to the Village (Indicative)

Precise figures will come from Phase 1 feasibility studies, but early-stage estimates suggest meaningful local economic value:

- **Energy currently imported**: approximately ¥40–60M per year leaves Mitsue's local economy as electricity payments. Local generation keeps a portion of this value within the village.
- **Taiken Koryukan maintenance**: currently ¥3–8M per year in upkeep with no return. Active use generates value from a previously stranded asset.
- **Direct employment**: an estimated 8–15 local jobs by Year 5 (forestry, facility operations, EV charging, administration).
- **Landowner income**: new revenue streams for private mountain owners through sustainable cedar harvesting.
- **Combined annual economic activity** by Year 5 (estimated): ¥28–67M, with a meaningful share retained locally.

These ranges are illustrative; the formal numbers will be developed with the village in Phase 1.

What We Are Asking For

At this early stage, we are seeking:

- An **opportunity to discuss** the project with village leadership
- Guidance on how to engage the **community (自治会) and residents** appropriately
- **A letter of interest** to support our application for initial feasibility study funding

We are **not** asking for village funds at this stage.

How the Project Will Be Organized

A dedicated **non-profit organization (NPO法人)** will be established to coordinate the project. The NPO will work transparently with:

- Mitsue Village Government
- Local residents and community associations (自治会)
- Private forest landowners
- Forestry contractors
- Nara Prefecture and national agencies (林野庁, METI)
- Academic and technical partners

Who We Are

Rob Oudendijk — Dutch electrical engineer, Mitsue resident since 2012 (Sugano), core hardware developer for Safecast (the global citizen science radiation monitoring network).

San Poisson — Project Manager

Advisors:

- **Joi Ito** (President, Chiba Institute of Technology)
- **Ray Ozzie** (Executive Chair, Blues)
- **Takuo Dome** (Professor, Osaka University Graduate School of Economics; Representative Director, Inochi Forum)
- **Evin Zoet** (Co-Representative Director, Transom)
- **Yoshiko Zoet-Suzuki** (Co-Representative Director, Transom)

Our Approach

- **Local first.** Mitsue residents and landowners are the foundation of this project.
- **No surprises.** We will share information openly and seek guidance at every step.
- **Patient and modest.** We are building for 25 years, not for headlines.
- **Replicable.** What we learn in Mitsue will be shared so other villages can benefit.

Next Step

We respectfully request a meeting with village leadership at their convenience to discuss the project and listen to your guidance.

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